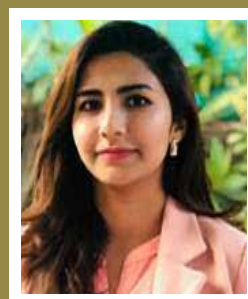




INDIA'S ULTRA-NATIONALISM: A BREEDING GROUND FOR RADICALISM



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ABSTRACT

India continues to portray itself as the largest democracy in the world while violating all norms of democracy with impunity. Motivated by fascism, RSS, the parent organization of BJP widely follows and propagates ideology of 'Hindutva' i.e. Hindu-ness. The RSS has always been active in India. However, since BJP came to power in 2014, its true motivations started to surface more aggressively. BJP leader Subramanian Swamy categorically stated how Muslims are not equal among equals in the Indian constitution and are generally just unequal to Hindus. This not only constitutes hatred and discrimination against the 200 million Indian Muslims but is also a violation of article 14 of the Indian constitution and Article 1 (2) of the UN Charter. Angry demonstrations by all segments of the civil society throughout India against the CAA and NRC that challenge the foundational concept of a secular India, have been dealt with by the Indian authorities including police and paramilitary forces in a manner reminiscent of the brutally high handed treatment of the people of occupied Kashmir. Inspired by Savarkar, the Hindutva ideology has drawn immense attention in its comparison to Hitler's ideology of fascism. The growing radicalization as a result of BJP policies is not only a threat to Muslims and other non-Hindu minorities in India but is also beginning to have spillover effects in the neighbouring countries. Ultra-nationalism propagated by Hindutva is making India a breeding ground for radicalism. Hindutva is a transnational threat with wide-ranging long-term implications for the stability and security of the South Asian region as well as for the world.

Key words: Ultra-nationalism in India, Hindutva, Radicalization, BJP, RSS, Modi Regime, India, South Asia



Even the gods worshipped in the South are different from the ones revered in the North. In fact the gods and heroes of the North are mentioned as the villains of the South, in the Hindu holy books

PRELUDE

India today is in the grip of ultra-Hindu nationalism that has its roots in the Hindutva ideology of the early 20th century. The followers of Hindu Mahasabha Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) have aspired for a Hindu Rashtra ever since the Hindu Mahasabha leader Vinayak Damodar Savarkar coined the term “Hindutva” in 1923 with the objective to create a collective Hindu identity. India, however, at the time of independence was declared a democratic republic and later a secular republic against the RSS aspirations. The RSS and BJP have since been exploiting secular and ethnic tensions within India to negate secularism and to create opportunities for the ascendance of ultra-Hindu nationalism. The Ayodhya movement can be considered as a watershed moment in the Hindu nationalists' rise in the Indian national politics.

The oppressive traits of ultra-Hindu nationalism have become more pervasive in India after Prime Minister Narendra Modi's re-election for the second term in 2019. It has challenged the Indian socio-political landscape through exclusionist policies such as the CAA, the NRC in Assam and its planned countrywide implementation, the Ghar Wapsi campaign, and cow raksha vigilantes. Such policies are creating a deep sense of anxiety and identity crisis among the minorities, especially Muslim citizens of India as well as in India's neighboring countries. Hindutva is not limited to the confines of the Indian State. Rather, its fascist overtures like abrogation of the special autonomous status of IIOJK have grave implications on Pakistan in particular and peace and stability of South Asia in general.

ULTRA-NATIONALISM IN INDIA: A CLASH WITH ITS DIVERSITY

In India there has never been a notion of a single Hindu nation even by the standards of Golwalkar. According to official Indian census, there are more than 19,500 languages or dialects spoken in India. The culture (language, cuisine, artifacts, clothing, rituals, ethics) greatly vary from North to South and East to West. Not just the culture, but physical features of people vary drastically as one moves from North to South and East to West. This signifies diverse gene pools in the region which are indicative of migrations.¹

Even the gods worshipped in the South are different from the ones revered in the North. In fact the gods and heroes of the North are mentioned as the villains of the south, in the Hindu holy books

Hindutva is a highly ethnocentric worldview, which emanates from an inferiority complex. Some extreme rightists in India have a hard time settling with the reality that Muslims ruled over them for almost 700 years. This is manifested in their pursuit to change the names of roads, monuments and cities, which were named after Muslim rulers (saffronisation). Even the iconic Taj Mahal is now being propagated as a symbol of oppression by Muslim rulers. History books are being rewritten to glorify the Hindu past to the exclusion of the Muslim rule. Hindutva is being promoted by the current BJP government to unite the Hindu race by creating a bogey enemy (Muslims).

The Hindutva ideology is in sync with India's aspiration for a major power status. It mobilizes almost 80% of Hindu population in India, by inculcating the passion to reclaim their greatness. It glorifies Hindu warrior gods and promotes bellicosity. This worldview fits well with the muscular stance of the BJP government and its military modernization programs. Ajit Doval, the National Security Advisor to Prime Minister Modi, emphasizes the need of being 'shaktishaali' reflecting Sarvarkar's saying, “first protect the cow and then worship it if you so desire”.²

Hinduisation of Contemporary India: Road to Catastrophe

Saffronization: India Rewriting History

Currently eight think tanks in India are believed to be shaping Indian foreign and security policies and all are being funded by RSS.³ This is





The accumulative view of Indian history is presented in a manner in which Muslims are interpreted as invaders and looters and Pakistan is seen as a residue of those Muslim invaders.

symptomatic of the fact that RSS thinking has uninterrupted access to the Indian strategic community to shape the policies according to the Hindutva worldview. The most prominent think tank is the India Foundation founded by one of the top members of RSS, Surya Doval, son of Ajit Doval, the National Security Advisor to the Prime Minister of India.

Another source of Indian strategic culture is the education syllabus. There are systematic efforts by RSS to change the education syllabi in which the notion of subjugation, humiliation and racial superiority are introduced repeatedly. Furthermore, measures are being taken to confiscate the Muslim contribution to Indian history and culture to demonize the centuries of Muslim rule in India. The accumulative view of Indian history is presented in a manner in which Muslims are interpreted as invaders and looters and Pakistan is seen as a residue of those Muslim invaders. India under BJP has thus accentuated hatred against Muslims and Pakistan.⁴

After coming to power, the BJP has resorted to changing the names of the monuments built during the Mughal rule and buildings and roads named after the Mughal kings in a bid to obliterate the Muslim milestones from Indian history. In August 2018, the BJP government renamed the historic Mughal Sarai Junction Railway Station in the state of Uttar Pradesh after the right-wing Hindu ideologue Deen Dayal Upadhyaya. In May 2015, many street signs in New Delhi carrying Muslim names including Aurangzeb Road, named after the sixth Mughal emperor, were painted black by Shiv Sena Hindustan, a radical Hindu organization. Later in that year, the ruling BJP officially changed the name of the Aurangzeb Road to A.P.J Abdul Kalam, a pro-BJP former President of India. In April

BJP government has laid the foundation of the Ram Mandir on 5 Aug 2020 so as to mark one year anniversary of Post 05 Aug decision of revocation of article 370 and 35A

2016, the BJP government in Haryana renamed the historic suburban city of Gurgaon next to Delhi as Gurugram. RSS has also demanded that many other places with Muslim names, including the cities of Ahmedabad, Hyderabad, and Aurangabad should be renamed.⁵

Signification of the Ayodhya Dispute

The Babri Masjid/Ram Janmabhumi (birthplace) dispute has polarized Muslims and Hindus, generating religious and political conflict. The flashpoint between Hindus and Muslims regarding the religious site dates back to 1528 when a masjid was built on the site which Hindus claimed as the 'Ram Janmabhoomi' (Ram's birthplace). This has been bitterly contested by both Muslims and Hindus, main issue being possession of the site.⁶ The matter has been subjudice for years until the Supreme Court allowed construction of Mandir recently. BJP government has laid the foundation of the Ram Mandir on 5 Aug 2020, so as to mark one year anniversary of Post 5 Aug decision of revocation of article 370 and 35A.⁷

The RSS boasts on its official website, "Apart from the Kashmir issue, the Sangh has all along been in the forefront in each and every national campaign, be it the "Ban Cow-slaughter" campaign of 1952 or the mass collection drive for the Vivekananda Rock Memorial at Kanyakumari in 1963. The Ekamata Rath Yatra of Ganga Jal and Bharatmata in 1983 and the later issue of Ram Janmabhoomi temple sponsored by the Sangh Pariwar, have irrefutably established that the Hindu society would respond like a "Virat Purush" (one corporate body), when the innate chord of Hindustan is stimulated to pulsate in every Hindu heart".⁸

Post 5 August Kashmir

One year has passed since India's unilateral decision to revoke Article 370 and 35A of the Indian Constitution that bifurcated the State of Jammu and Kashmir, with the explicit objective to change its demography and obliterate the identity of the people of Kashmir. The situation in IIOJK has not changed since. In fact it has aggravated the suffering of the people as the total blackout imposed by India has kept them confined to a virtual prison; the largest concentration camp in the world. Communications are still restricted, arrests and atrocities are a daily routine and the Covid-19 pandemic outbreak has added to the worsening health care for the Kashmiris. On August 22 2019, the Genocide Watch issued two alerts for IIOJK and India's Assam state.⁹ The Watch alerted that India was in violation on all the 10 scores that may lead India to be guilty of genocide.¹⁰



Pakistan's new map extends the border of the State of Jammu and Kashmir up to the Indian state of Himachal Pradesh as international border. This makes the Line of Control not just a military demarcation line but also a quasi-political dividing line

In addition, with little international media attention, India's Ministry of Home Affairs declared on 01 April 2020 that Kashmir would now be subject to a new domicile law, granting any individual who has resided in IIOJK for 15 years or longer and has studied in education institutes there for 15 years would have the right to own property.¹¹ More than 500,000 Hindu-Sikh families have been given IIOJK domiciles, all facilities have been withdrawn from former IIOJK Chief Ministers, and all Kashmiri IAS officers have been posted in less important positions. IIOJK has lost control over all universities, Hindu shrines, forest lands and tourist development authorities. Such Indian measures in occupied Kashmir are being implemented to abate the hold of Kashmir and Kashmiri's leadership over the state polity and compel IIOJK's merger with India.¹²

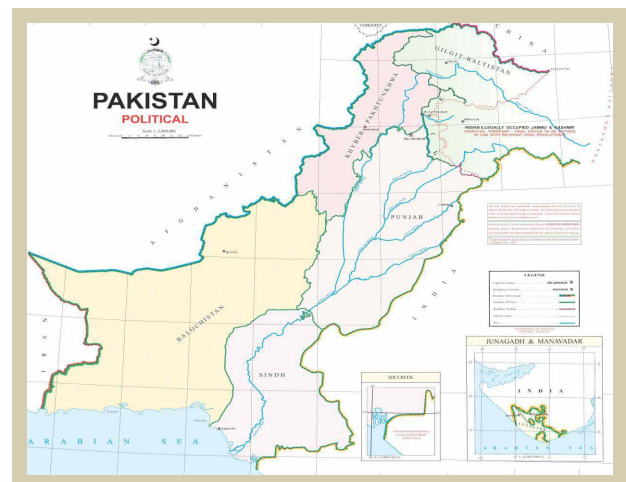
The blatant discrimination against religious minorities, particularly Muslim and Christian minorities has divided the Indian society into Them versus Us, a mindset that breeds hatred, intolerance and encourages ethnic clashes. This is already happening in India. In March 2020, the riots in Delhi were surreptitiously encouraged by the Delhi authorities and the police. The incidents of storming masjids, dragging and beating the Imams and the people who were praying inside, lynching of Muslim students in the prestigious Nehru University and Aligarh University were reminiscent of the communal riots that had erupted all over India but specially brutally in Delhi in 1984 after Prime Minister Indira Gandhi was assassinated by her own Sikh guards in retaliation for her decision to storm the Golden Temple in Amritsar.

On the anniversary of Post 5 August decision on Kashmir, Pakistan by releasing its new official political map has labeled the entire State of Jammu and Kashmir as disputed territory. Pakistan's new map extends the border of the State of Jammu and Kashmir up to the Indian state of Himachal Pradesh as international border. These changes bring the map closer to the political ground reality while abiding by the UNSC resolutions.¹³

Citizenship Amendment Act

A close study of the BJP manifestoes for the 2014 and 2019 elections reveal the crafty utilization of issues at hand by the Modi regime. In order to infuse confidence and win support of all the sub national and ethnic groups, the 2014 manifesto propagated unity among ranks; Sabka Sath Sabka Vikas, (progress, change and development for all). The manifesto specifically spoke of preserving Urdu and Muslim culture and heritage. Whereas, it openly talked about abrogation of Article 370 with regard to IIOJK, the manifesto intentionally made no mention at all of the damaging and more controversial article 35A. To invoke inclusivity and garner vote of Muslim clerics, it also talked about Madrassa preservation and modernization and declaring all communities as equal partners. Last but not the least, it sought to revive and improve India's relations with neighbours, with no conditionality or bias involved.¹⁴ With a reputation of being titled as the Butcher of Gujarat for the 2002 brutal massacre of Muslims (close to 800 Muslims were killed along with enormous loss to their property and livelihood), Modi won with huge majority of Hindu votes. Even many Muslims voted for BJP as they were disappointed with the Congress party and remembered Vajpayee's premiership in the 90s.

The 2019 manifesto with its slogan of Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat (one India, Pure India) makes an interesting 180 degree flip in terms of language, tenor and priority given to different agenda issues. The tone is belligerent and arrogant. It makes no mention of Urdu, Muslims or their rich culture, history or heritage, let alone preserving these norms. Rather Modi sought to maintain, conserve and promote Bhartiya faith and culture. The manifesto openly seeks implementing the National Register for Citizens countrywide, and the Citizenship Amendment Act Bill to protect and promote



<http://www.surveyofpakistan.gov.pk>



Hitler had also enacted a Citizenship Act to single out the Jewish population in 1935 just as the National Registry of Citizens by BJP. The Jews were sent to concentration camps

the Hindus, Jains, Buddhists and Sikhs. Muslims are not mentioned intentionally, to make the point that they are not considered part of the same religious order and, therefore, need to be treated differentially.¹⁵

The animosity and hatred of Hindutva mindset against Muslims is evident from the implementation of the National Register of Citizens (NRC) in Assam where 1.9 million Muslims have virtually been disenfranchised, and in Kashmir where 8 million Kashmiri Muslims have been placed under a virtual blackout and house arrest since August 2019. The Citizenship Amendment Act coupled with BJP's plan to implement NRC nationwide evoked protests and demonstrations in major cities across India which has halted due to COVID-19 pandemic.¹⁶

Hitler had also enacted a Citizenship Act to single out the Jewish population in 1935 just as the National Registry of Citizens by BJP. The Jews were sent to concentration camps. India is also constructing camps for Muslims who would fail to get their names registered as Indian citizens. The RSS aspiration for Akhand Bharat that would include Afghanistan, Pakistan and Bangladesh reflect an expansionist ideology very much akin to Hitler's ideology for a pure Aryan race and a greater Germany. There are striking similarities in their operational strategy also. Revocation of Articles 370 and 35A, annexation of IIOJK, NRC and CAA and to either reconvert Muslims or banish them into camps resembles Hitler's "Final Solution". State sponsored terrorism and mob violence against the Muslims is also reminiscent of Hitler's state sponsored torture and annihilation of the Jews. Textbooks on history are being rewritten in India to either distort or erase the 700 years of Muslim rule, just as the Nazis burned all Jewish books to erase their history. In the name of combatting infiltration, Modi regime is pushing population groups, specifically Assamese Muslims across the eastern border close to Bangladesh. Singling out and confining huge Muslim population groups into camps, is reminiscent of Nazi camps under the genocidal regime of Adolph Hitler, a precursor of the Holocaust.

The MAD Doctrine

The MAD doctrine refers to an amalgamation of three important minds in contemporary India, the

The MAD trio is the architect of the scheme to revoke Article 370 from the Indian Constitution and to introduce the intrinsically discriminatory CAA and NRC. Under their leadership the Hindutva ideology has become the keystone of India's policy

trio of Modi-Amit-Doyal, Modi being the Prime Minister, Amit Shah BJP's President and Minister for Home Affairs and Ajit Doyal the National Security Advisor to Prime Minister Modi. The three in high offices have extensive bearing over India's internal and external policies. Since BJP came to power under Modi's leadership, India has taken and implemented aggressive and belligerent decisions that have brought its secular credentials under question. The BJP government is being criticized within India for undermining the secular character of India.

Modi and Amit Shah are known stalwarts of Hindutva ideology and its propagating arm, the RSS. On the other hand, Ajit Doyal is a well-known "hawk" and a proponent of pugnacious strategic thought which is depicted by India's hostile military posture. The MAD trio is pursuing policies that would have long term regional as well as internal implications on India. The MAD trio is the architect of the scheme to revoke Article 370 from the Indian Constitution and to introduce the intrinsically discriminatory CAA and NRC. Under their leadership the Hindutva ideology has become the keystone of India's policy.

Moderates vs Extremists: Views within India

India is no longer the same India as was aspired for by its founding fathers. A critical analysis leads one to the observation that there is a gradual Indianisation or Hindutvisation of India, marked by ultra-nationalism. In the 21st century a wave of ultra-nationalism swept through various countries including those in Europe, the US and India.¹⁷ Under Modi's extremist driven mindset, India's saffronization

Syllabi are being altered countrywide to recreate history and Indian citizens are being discriminated and questioned about their allegiance to the "Motherland" on the basis of their religion



There is also a moderate class of intellectuals and civil society, who sincerely wish to preserve the secular credentials of India. They are deeply concerned that Hindu extremists would push the country toward an intolerant and extremist society

appears rapid and systematic. A quick glean into the past seven decades, predominantly ruled by secular Congress party governments shows a gradual and systemic move towards a predominantly Hindu state despite the professed adherence to tolerance, sectarian harmony and secularism.¹⁸

However, a large segment of Indian civil society did embrace and strongly believes in the ideals of inclusivity espoused by its founding fathers. They genuinely condemned and shunned the policies of the saffron brigade, whose follower Nathuram Godse had killed Mohandas Gandhi. But in today's India under a staunch follower of the RSS ideology, Godse is being worshipped, admired and revered. Mammoth statues and huge temples are being built to worship and idolize Hindu nationalists such as Godse. Syllabi are being altered countrywide to recreate history and Indian citizens are being discriminated and questioned about their allegiance to the "Motherland" on the basis of their religion. The BJP's exclusionist policies are creating social and political schisms within India. A vast majority in rural India identifies itself with the concept of a Hindu India only for Hindus.

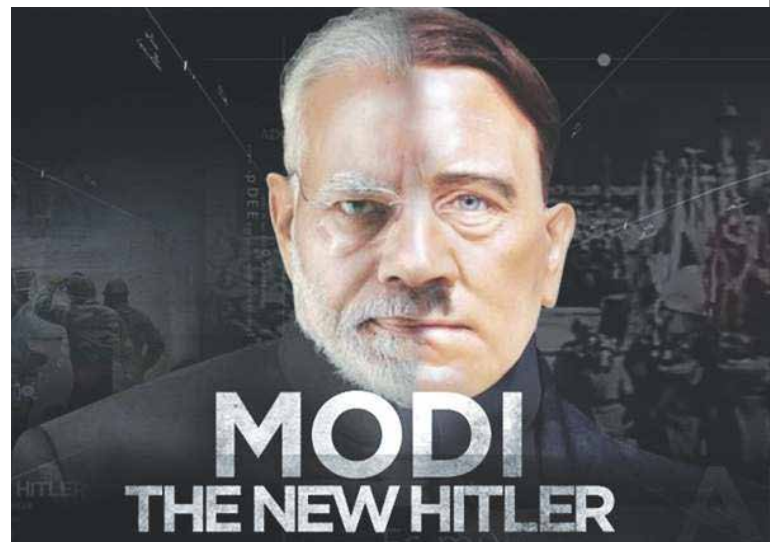
There is also a moderate class of intellectuals and civil society, who sincerely wish to preserve the secular credentials of India. They are deeply concerned that Hindu extremists would push the country toward an intolerant and extremist society. Many local human rights organizations and NGOs, several professional and political bodies, and members of the civil society do not agree with the BJP government's policies like the CAA and NRC. The Congress Party has called for repealing the CAA and "immediate stoppage of the NRC/NPR" on grounds that the "package" is unconstitutional and targets the poor and downtrodden. A meeting of various political parties convened by the Congress Party in a bid to showcase their unity on their opposition to the CAA, NRC and NPR, was attended by 20 parties that also adopted a joint resolution castigating BJP for embarked on a "dangerous course of sharpening communal polarization".¹⁹ Widespread protests, agitations and demonstrations were held in all big cities of India, especially in the north-eastern

part of India. Curfew was imposed in some parts of India to curtail the protests. The outbreak of Coronavirus pandemic compelled the demonstrators to call off protests, but in some cases, e.g. the Shaheen Bagh protests in Delhi, the police had to force the protestors to disperse.

Some outspoken voices from India like Arundhati Roy, Amitav Ghosh, Romila Thapar, Harsh Mander, Prof Anand Teltumbde raised their concerns and continue to do so.²⁰ Arundhati Roy was quick to respond to India's revocation of article 370 and 35A and said, "India has turned all of Kashmir into a giant prison camp".²¹ Ms. Roy is considered among India's prominent liberal voices. On CAA and NRC, she stated that, "It was not only against Muslims but also against Dalits and poor people in the country".²² A. G. Noorani, an eminent Indian scholar and expert on constitutional issues, differentiates Hinduism from Hindutva as he observes, "Hinduism is a noble and ancient faith. Hindutva is a modern and fascist concept". In his views, "the future of India is bleak".²³ Though Civil Society of India is vibrant and speaks up, it is still hard to predict the future of India's secularism and democracy.

Spillover Effects of Hindutva: India-Pakistan

Although India's relations with Pakistan have never been truly friendly, and mired more in acrimony and distrust, there have been brief periods in history during which the two enjoyed congenial terms. However, even at the worst of relations or during the phase of active conflict, the alienation, distrust and distance has not been so sharp and acute as it is today. The RSS activities in the neighbouring countries suggest Hindutva is an ideology with objectives that transcends the boundaries of contemporary India, making it a transnational threat. Implications





Pakistan has recently taken steps that encourage religious freedom. The opening of Kartarpur Corridor and restoration of religious sites of Hindus and Buddhists have helped to strengthen an atmosphere of inter-faith harmony in the country

specifically for Pakistan are far reaching since both Pakistan and India are immediate neighbours, share a history of animosity and mistrust and specifically because Pakistan is ideologically and demographically a Muslim state.

The rivalry between Pakistan and India hit a new low in 2019 when the issue of the Kashmir dispute reached a new vulnerable point that had the potential to bring India and Pakistan on the brink of an all-out war. The ultra-Hinduism and mounting Hindutva following, the officially sponsored persecution against Muslims in India and the standoff between Pakistan and India on Kashmir, among other factors, serve as enabling as well as multiplying factors for the current disconnect between Pakistan and India. This has further exacerbated the already searing mistrust between the two countries.²⁴

Pakistan on the other hand, has recently taken steps that encourage religious freedom. The opening of Kartarpur Corridor and restoration of religious sites of Hindus and Buddhists have helped to strengthen an atmosphere of inter-faith harmony in the country. Whereas the exact opposite of this been observed in India. The so-called largest secular democracy of the world has fallen victim to a wave of Hindutva intolerance in a manner that it is hard to find even the

With the growth of Hindu ultra-nationalism, the population of the whole region is very probable to be affected negatively

remnants of what was once Gandhi's and Nehru's India.

The BJP government in India has adopted a hardline approach and a muscular style of diplomacy in dealing with Pakistan as exhibited by its decision to re-annex IIOJK by revoking Article 370 and 35(A) of the Indian Constitution in violation of the UN Security Council Resolutions. The possibility, therefore, does exist that the tensions and strains in Pakistan-India relations may lead to occasional low intensity armed conflicts. However, as long as both Pakistan and India maintain a credible nuclear deterrent, it is doubtful that the tensions between the two countries would escalate to an all-out war between them.²⁵

Growing Radicalism in India: A Transnational Threat

Expansion of the Hindutva mindset within India, is also posing grave challenges for its regional neighbours. The RSS has been expanding its influence in the neighbouring countries that have Hindu or Buddhist majority or large minorities. This is likely to be a serious issue for minorities in those countries with serious implications for the security and stability of the whole region.²⁶ Similarly, Hindutva mindset is encouraging and propagating extremism in the South Asian region. The region already suffers from the problem of terrorism and extremism. With the growth of Hindu ultra-nationalism, the population of the whole region is very probable to be affected negatively. Some examples of inimical impact of Hindutva are discussed below:-

- **Threat of Growing Extremism and the Effect on Indian Diaspora.** The RSS is seeking to impose a Hindu supremacist ideology in a country (India) that is diverse in its ethnic, religious, cultural and sectarian landscape. Prime Minister Modi's high-handed policies have created tensions and divisions on sectarian and cultural fault lines in India. The looming threat of Hindutva will not remain limited within the confines of the Indian state. The Indian diaspora all over the world may get sucked into such narrow interpretation of nationhood, thus creating tensions within the Indian community abroad, which would have a spillover effect on the Pakistani community residing in those countries.²⁷ The world must be





This declaration of Indian residents as non-citizens and stateless is expected to generate an illegal immigration and refugee influx in neighboring Bangladesh

cautioned of the threat being posed in South Asia by proponents of Hindutva who draw inspiration from Hitler and Mussolini.

- **Assam Crisis: A Question for Bangladesh.** Bangladesh attributing to the nature of its independence struggle has experienced Indian influence. The countries already have border disputes. Currently, rising Hindutva sentiments in India are sending tremors in Bangladesh as well. Several incidents of shoot and kill by Indian border forces against Bangladesh's Border Security Forces (BSF) were reported in 2019.²⁸ As the state of Bangladesh tries to cater to the Burmese refugee crisis, India from the other front is set to launch another refugees crisis along with border violations. India's National Register of Citizens (NRC) developed across ethno-nationalist lines distinguishes thousands of Indian citizens of Assam as non-citizens. This declaration of Indian residents as non-citizens and stateless is expected to generate an illegal immigration and refugees influx in neighboring Bangladesh, which already hosts Muslim refugees who have fled religious persecution in Myanmar.²⁹ Moreover, BJP leader Ram Madhav had already questioned a separate existence of Bangladesh and Pakistan in RSS version of the Indian map of Akhand Bharat in 2015.³⁰ Also, the RSS controlled publication Suruchi Prakash published a map called "Punyaboomi Bharat". The map not only includes Pakistan and Bangladesh but also Afghanistan, Sri Lanka and Myanmar in the Bharat 'Rashtra'. Golwalkar espoused that "Akhand Bharat" will be based on "Hindu Culture" and will spread RSS ideology.³¹ This whole scenario poses a serious challenge for Bangladesh and relationship between India and Bangladesh is coming under stress. Bangladesh will most likely resist a wave of migrants from India (NRC). Thus, a serious refugee crisis that appears to be building

India's hegemonic designs in Nepal have fostered strong anti-India sentiments among the Nepalese public, coupled with Nepal's increasing inclination towards China



up that would sour relations between India and Bangladesh.

- **RSS in Nepal.** India has, as a policy, played the role of a regional bully to keep its smaller neighbours dependent on its largesse. India keeps creating situations where it offers assistance to resolve that situation so that weaker neighbours remain beholden to India. The state of Nepal, being one, was extremely disturbed at India's expansionist designs since it declared itself a republic after abolishing the Monarchy in 2006. While Hindu nationalists have reportedly been conducting several terror-led activities in Nepal, an issue surfaced on 2 November 2019 when an Indian official map was found showing the Nepalese sovereign territory of Kalapani as part of India. The Indian move blatantly violates the 1816 Sugali Treaty signed between the East India Company and Nepal. India's hegemonic designs in Nepal have fostered strong anti-India sentiments among the Nepalese public, coupled with Nepal's increasing inclination towards China.³²
- **Sri-Lanka.** According to Indian Defense Analyst, Lt Col (R) Susantha Seneviratne, at least 17 branches of RSS are operational in Sri-Lanka. The purpose is to spread the ideology of Hindutva. He noted that gathering information might be one reason why the Indians stationed RSS in Sri Lanka and not to carry an attack or to create chaos.³³

Conclusion

- Of particular interest in this environment is the question as to what impact will the BJP policies have on the South Asian region, if the current trends of officially inspired hate speech, sectarian intolerance and persecution of minorities persist in India?



India has scornfully spurned every effort and several offers by Pakistan for a peaceful resolution of the Kashmir dispute. Hence Kashmir remains a festering flash point between Pakistan and India

- India is home to 72 different types of separatist movements since its independence. While these movements kept simmering for many years, they have started indicating overtones of intense impressions. The intolerance depicted toward the minorities has now started to induce reactions. This is primarily evident in Kashmir, the abrogation of articles 370 and 35A, deployment of about 900,000 troops, the brutal communication clampdown, the imposition of Article 144, abduction of Kashmiri political leadership, complete media blackout and every other possible violation of human rights have kept the Kashmiris on the edge.
- India has scornfully spurned every effort and several offers by Pakistan for a peaceful resolution of the Kashmir dispute. Hence, Kashmir remains a festering flash point between Pakistan and India. The perception that it is only a matter of time or just a miscalculation by either side may degenerate into active confrontation is not farfetched. India's hatred for Muslims, depicted at even the highest official levels, shows how deep its hatred is towards Muslims and the Kashmiri Muslims are no exception. Such bellicosity has a direct bearing on Pakistan-India relations.

NEWS LIVE TV INDIA TODAY APP MAGAZINE

Rajasthan rewrites history: Maharana Pratap, not Akbar, won Battle of Haldighati

Rajasthan education board has approved changing its Class X history books to teach students that the Rana of Mewar, Maharana Pratap was the victor against Mughal emperor Akbar during the 16th-century Battle of Haldighati.

Growing saffronisation of India

The ethnic and religious based violence in India or essentially the Hindutva ideology has the potential to plunge the whole region into a security quagmire

- The implementation of NRC in Assam which disenfranchises almost 2 million people, mostly Muslims, is an act of unprecedented injustice against minorities. Nagaland has unfurled its own flag and anthem, and Manipur has formed a government in exile. Most importantly, the Khalistan Movement for a separate homeland for the Sikhs, show how the BJP's high-handed policies are encouraging centrifugal movements within India. The BJP has landed India on the path to an utterly unpredictable future. If any of these separatist movements gets intensified in the future, it will have a domino effect first in India and then in the region, primarily in Pakistan. Hence, the ethnic and religious based violence in India or essentially the Hindutva ideology has the potential to plunge the whole region into a security quagmire.
- It is ironical that extension of global identity matters more than the principles of liberal order, peace and prosperity, and the rule of law. The emergence of operational convergence between the far-right of Europe and the far right of the Sub-continent glorifies fascism. In the last decade, non-Islamic extremism is on the rise globally but the scholarship on extremism in the west is still focused on Islamic extremism with a magnifying glass ignoring any other form of non-Islamic extremism. Thus getting a cue from President Trump's bias against Islam, Prime Minister Modi is on a rampage against his own Muslim citizens.
- In the international arena, more importance is given to the domestic Indian political discourse than to what is being said in Pakistan about developments in India. An internationally relevant state enjoys the power to project anything to its advantage within its region or the international system. This has particularly been the equation between India and Pakistan in the

It is unfortunate that in India measures are being taken to confiscate the Muslim contribution to Indian history and culture and demonize the 700 years of Muslim rule in India



The situation is not likely to change, rather it will deteriorate further. Therefore, there are chances of increased volatility inside India and within the region

last two and half decade. Thus to Pakistan's chagrin, major weapon producing powers are wooing New Delhi to sell their defense equipment. This is and will contribute to the region's security imbalance and instability.

- The Hindutva mindset/ideology has penetrated deep in the Indian strategic culture. There is uninterrupted access of Indian strategic community to shape the policies according to Hindutva world view. The Indian society has veered towards religious extremism, intolerance and bigotry. Prime Minister Modi's high-handed policies have created tensions and divisions on sectarian and cultural fault lines in India, often prone towards violence. It is unfortunate that in India measures are being taken to confiscate the Muslim contribution to Indian history and culture and demonize the 700 years of Muslim rule in India. Indian history is being distorted to present Muslims as invaders and looters. Pakistan is seen as a residue of those Muslim invaders.
- With an increase in hate crimes against Muslims in India in recent years, it is feared that the world's largest democracy is becoming dangerously intolerant and belligerent under the Hindu nationalist BJP regime. Despite resistance from the Indian civil society and the Congress Party representatives, Modi is emboldened by belligerence, defiance and mockery of international norms and by other major powers of the world, e.g. US and some European countries. He is determined to change the nature of contemporary India under the RSS influence.
- Swamy's statement shows how bigoted Indian mind is to believe Muslims are a different category and are not equal to Hindus. He is resonating with the BJP-RSS government's basic philosophy. It would not be wrong to say that the Indian State has landed itself into a serious conflict with the principle of equality protected in article 14 of the Indian Constitution and Article 1 (2) of the UN Charter.³⁴ This represents a long-term trend with dangerous implications for religious minorities in India as well as peace and stability in South Asia. The situation is not likely to change, rather it will deteriorate further. Therefore, there are chances of increased volatility inside India and within the region.

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A Muslim girl holding a placard condemns the Supreme Court of India's judgment on the Babri Masjid